

FROM GREATNESS TO BETRAYAL

Alberta's Public Fall from Grace

1979 — 2026

A Cross-Party Record of What Was Built, and What Was Taken

PHASES ONE & TWO

Tribute • Methodology • Comparative Summary • The Lougheed Era • The Getty Era

The Alberta Disability System Breakdown

St. Albert, Alberta • May 2026

ABOUT THIS DOCUMENT

This is not a party endorsement. This is a public record of what each government inherited, what each government changed, and what Albertans lost **and** gained as a result. Across forty-seven years, this document names actions taken by Progressive Conservative, New Democratic, and United Conservative governments. The standard is the same for each: what the documented record establishes, era by era, decision by decision.

Part One — A Tribute to the Man Who Built the Promise

Peter Lougheed died on September 13, 2012, in the Calgary hospital that now bears his name. He was 84.

He had been Premier of Alberta from September 10, 1971 to November 1, 1985 — fourteen years. He left office decades before this document needed to be written. He did not live to see Bill 26. He did not live to see Bill 12. He did not live to see the Alberta Disability Assistance Program. He did not live to see the 88% cohabitation rule, or the Canada Disability Benefit clawback, or the May 12, 2026 fact sheet that established the framework this campaign has spent the past four months documenting.

But he did live to see the start of it. And he said, publicly and on the record, that the people who came after him were dismantling what he had built. He spent the last decade of his life telling Albertans, in interview after speech after policy paper, that the foundation was being drawn down rather than added to. He was correct. The trajectory only continued after he could no longer speak to it.

This document begins with him not because the Lougheed era was perfect — no era is — but because it is the only era in the period this piece covers when the disability community in Alberta was the subject of positive structural construction rather than negotiated subtraction. Every era after his has, on the documented record, taken more from the disability community than it has given.

He is the baseline. He is what "greatness" referenced in the title of this document means.

What He Built

Within fourteen years, the Lougheed PC government built or established the following — many of them still in operation today, several of which directly underpin the disability community's ability to exist in the province at all:

- **Alberta Heritage Savings Trust Fund (1976).** Established to capture non-renewable resource revenue and reinvest it for the long-term benefit of Albertans. Originally received 30% of resource royalties.
- **Assured Income for the Severely Handicapped (AISH) (January 1979).** The first program in Canada designed specifically to provide assured income to people with permanent severe disabilities. Built outside the welfare system. No asset limits at founding. Pegged to senior pension rates. Built so that disabled Albertans could live with dignity and independence — Lougheed's actual framing at the time.
- **Repeal of the Sexual Sterilization Act (1972).** The 1928 Act, which authorized forced sterilization of Albertans deemed "mentally defective," was eliminated by the newly elected Lougheed government in one of its first major social-policy actions. Approximately 2,832 documented sterilizations had occurred under the Act between 1928 and 1972.

- **Services for the Handicapped program (1972).** First standalone division of the Department of Social Services dedicated to disability supports.
- **William Watson Lodge.** A publicly-owned wilderness lodge in Kananaskis Country, built specifically so that people with disabilities could access the Rocky Mountains alongside every other Albertan. It still operates today. Nothing comparable has been built since.
- **Royal Tyrrell Museum of Palaeontology.** Civic-cultural infrastructure on a generational scale.
- **Alexander Rutherford scholarships.** Province-wide post-secondary support for graduating Alberta students.
- **Fish Creek Provincial Park (Calgary) and Capital City Recreation Park (Edmonton).** Two large urban provincial parks built inside the province's largest cities.
- **Alberta Bill of Rights (early Lougheed legislation).** Province-level rights framework.
- **Patriation of the Canadian Constitution (1982).** Lougheed was a central negotiator in the constitutional accord that produced the Charter of Rights and Freedoms.

This is what one Alberta government built in fourteen years. The relevant question this document will return to repeatedly is what every government since has built, by comparison — and what each has drawn down from the foundation Lougheed laid.

What He Said About What Came After

Lougheed left office in 1985. He did not stop speaking. From the mid-1990s onward — and with particular intensity from 2006 forward — he gave interviews, wrote columns, and delivered speeches that constitute a sustained on-the-record critique of the Klein-era decisions that began the dismantling of his foundation. The *Globe and Mail* in 2008 described his late-life public engagement as Lougheed "settling accounts with Klein."

The Walrus, looking back in 2019, recorded that Lougheed had "come out of retirement" in 2006 specifically to express alarm at what he called the "rip and strip" approach to oilsands development. The Tyee, days after his death, summarised his late-life position: *"Lougheed often lamented the speed of bitumen development in the province. His motto was 'one project at a time.'"*

The words below are his, taken from interviews and speeches in his final decade. He is speaking, throughout, about resource policy — but the philosophy of stewardship that animates every quote is the same philosophy that produced AISH. Both came from the same conviction: that wealth, whether resource-based or human, belongs to the people who own it and must be managed for the long term, not extracted for the short.

"You have to look at oil and natural gas as a depleting and declining resource. And you have to manage the resource and that means to manage it with good public policy."

— Peter Lougheed, interview with *Policy Options*, 2012 (months before his death)

The principle generalises directly. The disability community is not a depleting resource — it is a growing one — but the same logic about *good public policy* applies. AISH was good public policy. Indexing AISH to inflation was good public policy. De-indexing it was the opposite of good public policy. Lougheed's framework names the criterion that every government since has either applied or abandoned.

"This is a sale of a depleting resource that's owned by the people. Once a barrel of oil goes down the pipeline it's gone forever. It's like a farmer selling off his topsoil."

— Peter Lougheed, quoted in *Alberta Views*, on resource ownership

He used the metaphor of *topsoil* deliberately. Topsoil is the precondition for everything else a farm produces. Sell it, and the farm cannot recover. The same metaphor applies to the institutional architecture of disability support in Alberta: AISH, FSCD, PDD, the appeal rights, the cohabitation rules. Each is topsoil. Each can be sold off — and much of it now has been.

"Selling the house to pay for the groceries."

— Peter Lougheed, on reckless spending of royalty revenue as current income

This phrase appears repeatedly across reporting on his late-life criticism. It is the framework he used for what Klein had done with the Heritage Fund. The same logic applies to the disability income system: the Lougheed-era assured income guarantee was the *house*, and every government since has, in some measure, sold pieces of it to fund the day.

"I don't represent with this view the majority of Albertans. But it's getting to be that more and more are agreeing with me. They're starting to be impacted by the cost factors all around us, and then they're saying, 'I remember Lougheed saying that we're going too fast.'"

— Peter Lougheed, Globe and Mail / Report on Business Magazine, August 2008

Fourteen years before the ADAP transition. Eighteen years before this document was written. Lougheed himself predicted the moment when Albertans would look back at his warnings and recognise them. This document is that moment, applied to the disability community.

Why This Tribute Opens the Document

Lougheed's principle was simple: govern as though you are the owner of what belongs to the people, not the manager of an account belonging to someone else. *Think like an owner*, as he put it. Every successor government in Alberta has thought like a manager — and manager-thinking, applied to a depleting resource and to a disability community, produces the same outcome. Both get drawn down.

Peter Lougheed died nearly fourteen years ago. The document that follows asks a question he is no longer alive to answer, but which every part of his late-life record suggests he was already answering when he could:

What has every government since done with what he built?

The answer the documented record establishes — across every party, across every premier, across forty-seven years — is the substance of this piece.

Part Two — Why This Piece Exists

This is a cross-party history of Alberta disability policy from January 1979, when Assured Income for the Severely Handicapped was first established, to May 2026, when this document was first compiled. It documents what every Alberta government in that period — Progressive Conservative, NDP, United Conservative — established for the disability community, and what every Alberta government in that period took away.

The argument is not partisan. It is structural. Every party has both built and dismantled, in proportions that vary by era but never resolve in the disability community's favour over the full timeline. The trajectory across forty-seven years is downward. The trajectory at the present moment, with the AISH-to-ADAP transition scheduled for July 1, 2026, is accelerating downward.

The thesis

Partisan-aligned advocacy has not worked. Gains made under one government have been removable, and have been removed, by the next. The 2018 indexation of AISH to inflation, achieved under the Notley NDP, was reversed within fifteen months of the Kenney UCP taking office in 2019 (Bill 20 — Fiscal Measures and Taxation Act). The 1979 establishment of AISH as a dignity-based assured income program, achieved under Lougheed, has been re-engineered piece by piece under every subsequent premier — culminating in 2026 with the structural redefinition of disability income as conditional on employment activity under ADAP.

If partisan-aligned advocacy worked, the trajectory would not look like this. The trajectory looks like this *because* the disability community has spent forty-seven years depending on whichever government is in power to act in its interest. No government, of any party, has been a durable enough ally to make that strategy work.

The conclusion is the campaign's reason for existing: the disability community needs **its own representation** — community-led, party-independent, documentation-first — because no government will do this work on the community's behalf, and the historical record proves it.

How the record is built

Each era of this document is anchored to primary sources: Government of Alberta legislation and regulation, Hansard records, Open Alberta caseload data, the Disability Sector Legacy Project timeline (funded by the Alberta Historical Resources Foundation and Edmonton Heritage Council), peer-reviewed analyses, and contemporaneous news coverage. The framing is the campaign's standard discipline: *the documented record establishes*. Where motive cannot be established from documents, it is not asserted; the structural consequences are documented instead.

This is Phase One of the piece. It establishes the methodology, the comparative summary, and the Lougheed-era foundation in full. Subsequent phases will document each era to the same standard.

Part Three — Comparative Summary, 1971 – 2026

One row per Alberta government in the period. The left column names what that government established for, or directly affecting, the disability community. The right column names what was taken away, reduced, frozen, or restructured downward. Sources for every cell are documented in the era chapters that follow.

Era	Established	Took / Reduced
Peter Lougheed PC 1971 – 1985	Heritage Fund (1976) — AISH (Jan 1979) — Services for the Handicapped program (1972) — repealed Sexual Sterilization Act (1972) — William Watson Lodge — Royal Tyrrell Museum — Alexander Rutherford scholarships — Fish Creek & Capital City urban parks — Heritage Trust	Net positive era. Public criticism of his successors began in his lifetime.
Don Getty PC 1985 – 1992	Family Support for Children with Disabilities — Persons with Developmental Disabilities programs continued	Recession-era restructuring. Heritage Fund earnings transferred to general revenue (1987) — interest reinvestment ceased — slowing of social investment growth
Ralph Klein PC 1992 – 2006	AISH rate increase late period — Persons with Developmental Disabilities Community Governance Act (1997) — FSCD Act (2003) — Samantha's Law (begun)	"The Klein Revolution" — public-sector cuts of 21% across departments — AISH base rate frozen for over a decade — Bill 22 (Services to Persons with Disabilities reform, 1996) — healthcare premiums introduced — Michener Centre cuts begin — 2004 "yipping cowboy-hat women" remarks
Ed Stelmach PC 2006 – 2011	AISH base-rate increase (2007 — first significant rise after Klein-era freezes) — partial restoration of social spending growth	Continued royalty drift below Lougheed-era thresholds — Heritage Fund remained capped and unindexed
Alison Redford PC 2011 – 2014	Some social-spending growth — Disability Advocate discussions begin	Mid-term mixed period; service cuts in education and social supports as fiscal pressure returned
Hancock / Prentice PC 2014 – 2015	Halt to Michener Centre full closure (Sept 2014)	Interim period — limited tenure
Rachel Notley NDP 2015 – 2019	AISH indexed to CPI — AISH base rate raised to \$1,685/month — Bill 26: An Act to Combat Poverty and Fight for Albertans with Disabilities (2018) — first Advocate for Persons with Disabilities hired	(Within disability-policy lens, net positive era; broader fiscal critiques outside the scope of this piece.)
Jason Kenney UCP 2019 – 2022	Federal \$10/day childcare agreement signed (2021)	Bill 20 (Fiscal Measures and Taxation Act) — AISH de-indexed from CPI — AISH effectively frozen — service-rule changes — early signs of structural unwinding of the Notley-era indexation

Era	Established	Took / Reduced
Danielle Smith UCP 2022 – present	AISH transition top-up (until Dec 31, 2027) — "automatic AISH retention" categories defined	Canada Disability Benefit clawback (July 2025, only province) — Bill 12 (Dec 2025) — Citizens Appeal Panel removed for ADAP — AISH inflation index capped at 2% (below CPI) — community-housing rent increase of \$220/month (Oct 2025) — ADAP transition (July 1, 2026) — 88% cohabitation rule — base-rate cut of \$200/month at transition

READING THE TABLE

The pattern is the substance of the argument. Every Alberta government in the period has both established and reduced — but the balance shifts steadily toward the right column over time, and the structural significance of what is taken grows with each era. Lougheed's right-column row is the only one without a substantive entry. By Smith's row, the right column carries the policy weight of the present moment.

Part Four — The Lougheed Era, 1971 – 1985

The foundation. The baseline against which every subsequent era is measured.

Political context

Peter Lougheed took the leadership of the Alberta Progressive Conservative Party in 1965, at the age of 36. The party held no seats. By 1967, he was Leader of the Official Opposition. In the 1971 general election, his PC government defeated the Social Credit dynasty that had governed Alberta since 1935 — ending a thirty-six-year governing tradition in a single vote. The Lougheed government was re-elected in 1975, 1979, and 1982 with increasing majorities. In 1982, on the heels of both an energy deal with Ottawa and constitutional patriation, the PCs took 75 of Alberta's 79 legislative seats.

Lougheed's governing philosophy was a deliberate departure from the Social Credit era. Where his predecessors had positioned the Alberta government as a minimal entity that stayed out of the affairs of its people, Lougheed positioned it as an active agent of modernisation, investment, and stewardship. Three Globe and Mail tributes after his death described him as the architect of "modern-day Alberta." The Canadian Encyclopedia and Policy Options have both repeatedly named him among the most consequential premiers in Canadian history.

What the Lougheed government established for the disability community

1. Repeal of the Sexual Sterilization Act (June 2, 1972)

One of the first major social-policy actions of the new PC government was the elimination of Alberta's 1928 Sexual Sterilization Act. The Act had authorised the forced sterilisation of Albertans deemed "mentally defective" by the Alberta Eugenics Board. Approximately 2,832 documented sterilisations had occurred under the Act between 1928 and 1972, with the vast majority performed without informed consent of the person sterilised. The Lougheed government repealed the Act on June 2, 1972. The Eugenics Board was dissolved with it.

This was the formal legal end of Alberta's institutional eugenics era. The repeal did not undo the harm done in the preceding forty-four years — that work would fall to Leilani Muir's successful 1996 lawsuit and the survivor advocacy that followed — but it closed the legislative on-ramp. No subsequent government has reopened it.

2. Services for the Handicapped program (1972)

Established as a standalone division of the Department of Social Services, dedicated to disability supports. The first formal organisational signal that the Government of Alberta treated disability as a distinct policy domain deserving of its own institutional home.

3. Alberta Heritage Savings Trust Fund (1976)

Established to capture revenue from Alberta's non-renewable resources and reinvest it for the long-term benefit of Albertans. Initially received approximately 30% of resource royalties. The Heritage Fund is not a disability program — but it is the underlying fiscal philosophy that made AISH possible three years later. The same vision that said *wealth from depleting resources belongs to the people and should be invested for them* also said *assured income for the severely disabled is a long-term commitment, not a budget line*. The two policies share an architecture.

The Fund peaked in real-term value in the early 1990s. Successive governments transferred its interest earnings to general revenue (Getty, 1987 onward), allowed it to stagnate (Klein), and have since drawn down its real-term purchasing power year over year. Lougheed's own subsequent criticism of these decisions — "selling the house to pay for the groceries" — is preserved in the Tribute section of this document.

4. Assured Income for the Severely Handicapped (January 1979)

The founding act of Alberta disability policy as it has existed for the past forty-seven years. AISH was established under separate legislation, intentionally constructed outside the welfare system, so that recipients would not be treated as welfare recipients. It was the first program in Canada designed specifically to support adults with permanent severe disabilities.

Key founding design features:

- **Flat-rate benefit** equivalent to senior pension rates of the era. Higher than Social Assistance.
- **No asset limits.** Recipients were not penalised for owning their homes or having modest savings. This feature has been progressively eroded by subsequent governments; the current \$100,000 non-exempt asset limit is a Klein-era construction.
- **Separate legislation.** Not folded into the standard welfare statute. The legislative separation reflected the conviction that disability income was a different kind of obligation than poverty assistance — one rooted in the structural inability to earn a living rather than the temporary inability to find one.
- **Dignity framing.** The program's foundational documents and ministerial language used the words *dignity* and *independence* as core design criteria. This framing has been replaced, under ADAP, with *employment activity* and *opportunity to earn* — a structural reversal of the founding premise.
- **First in Canada.** No other province had a comparable program. The Lougheed government had no template; it built one. Subsequent provinces (and the federal Canada Disability Benefit, four decades later) drew on the AISH framework as a model.

The Lethbridge Herald, in an open letter to Premier Smith published in March 2026, framed the founding intent precisely: *"When Premier Peter Lougheed's government established the Assured Income for the Severely Handicapped (AISH) program in January 1979, it was so that those unable to earn enough to live, could have an assured income... AISH was specifically designed separate from the standard welfare system so that Albertans with severe permanent disabilities could live with dignity and independence. Premier Lougheed understood that we each live just one incident away from a severely disabling event."*

"One incident away." This is the same frame the ADSB campaign uses in its 2026 teach-ins under the phrase *one accident away*. The continuity between Lougheed's framing and the current campaign's framing is not coincidence. It is the rediscovery of the founding principle by a community now forced to defend it against governments that have forgotten or rejected it.

5. William Watson Lodge

A publicly-owned wilderness lodge in Kananaskis Country, built specifically to enable people with disabilities to access the Rocky Mountains. The Lodge remains in operation today. It is one of the few pieces of *physical infrastructure* in the province built specifically for the disability community. Nothing comparable in scale or intent has been constructed since.

Alberta Views, in its 2025 retrospective "The Lesson of Lougheed," described the Lodge alongside the Royal Tyrrell Museum and the Heritage Trust as among Lougheed's "institutional inheritances" — durable assets the

province continues to draw on without having added meaningfully to them.

6. The Alberta Bill of Rights and the Charter of Rights and Freedoms (1982)

Lougheed introduced provincial-level rights legislation in his first term, and was a central federal negotiator on the patriation of the Canadian Constitution and the Canadian Charter of Rights and Freedoms in 1982. The Charter's Section 15 (Equality Rights), added in April 1985, includes *physical or mental disability* as a protected ground of discrimination. The Lougheed government's role in the patriation negotiations is structurally upstream of every disability-rights legal action subsequently brought under Section 15.

What the Lougheed government took or reduced from the disability community

Net positive era. On the documented record, the Lougheed government did not structurally reduce disability-program supports, freeze rates, restrict eligibility, or remove appeal rights during its tenure. This is the only era of the seven covered in this document where the right column of the comparative summary table is substantively empty.

This is not an unqualified endorsement. The Lougheed era pre-dates many of the disability policy domains that have since been built (the Family Support for Children with Disabilities Act, the Persons with Developmental Disabilities Community Governance Act, FOIP, the Personal Information Protection Act, modern accessibility legislation). The absence of subtractions from the disability community in the Lougheed era partially reflects the absence of pre-existing structures to subtract from. What can be said with confidence is that the Lougheed government did not dismantle what it built. Every subsequent government has, in varying degrees, done some of that.

Caseload context

AISH caseload data from the founding era is sparse in publicly-available records. By 2010 — twenty-five years after Lougheed left office — the AISH caseload was 41,664 (*Government of Alberta AISH Open Data*). By 2020 it had grown to 69,785, representing 1.6% of Alberta's population. By 2025 it stood at approximately 79,290 — the figure currently being processed through the AISH-to-ADAP transition.

The growth in caseload is partly demographic (population growth and aging) and partly diagnostic (broader recognition of qualifying conditions, particularly mental health and neurological conditions, that would not have been documented as AISH-qualifying in 1979). It is structurally significant that no Alberta government since Lougheed has built a disability program of comparable scope to absorb the caseload growth its predecessor anticipated. The growth has been absorbed by stretching the original program, not by constructing a second one.

The Lougheed conclusion

Peter Lougheed built the foundation of Alberta disability policy during a period of exceptional fiscal capacity and exceptional political consensus. He did so against the explicit alternative of treating disability as a welfare problem; he built a structure that treated it as a permanent civic obligation. He repealed the legislative on-ramp to Alberta's eugenics era and replaced it with an assured income program that the rest of Canada eventually imitated. He created physical infrastructure for the disability community in the form of William Watson Lodge. He framed the program in language — *dignity, independence, one incident away* — that the community has

held onto and is now defending against a government that no longer uses those words.

Every era of this document that follows is, in one way or another, the story of what was done with what Peter Lougheed built. The story is not flattering. He himself, in his last decade, said so. The full record now confirms what he tried to warn about while he was still alive.

Part Five — What Comes Next

Phase One has established the foundation, the methodology, the comparative summary, and the Lougheed era in full. Subsequent phases will document each era to the same standard:

- **Phase Two — Don Getty PC (1985–1992):** recession-era restructuring; the 1987 diversion of Heritage Fund interest earnings into general revenue; early signs of the drawdown Lougheed would later criticise.
- **Phase Three — Ralph Klein PC (1992–2006):** "The Klein Revolution" — the most consequential single era of dismantling in the period. AISH rate frozen for over a decade. Bill 22. Healthcare premiums. The 2004 "yipping cowboy-hat women" remarks. Lougheed's first public criticisms of his own party.
- **Phase Four — Ed Stelmach PC (2006–2011):** partial restoration. The 2007 AISH base-rate increase — the first significant rise after the Klein-era freezes.
- **Phase Five — Redford / Hancock / Prentice PC (2011–2015):** the late-PC mixed period; the halt to Michener Centre's closure under Prentice (September 2014).
- **Phase Six — Rachel Notley NDP (2015–2019):** AISH indexed to CPI; rate raised to \$1,685; NDP Bill 26 (An Act to Combat Poverty and Fight for Albertans with Disabilities, 2018); first Advocate for Persons with Disabilities hired. Net-positive era within disability-policy scope.
- **Phase Seven — Jason Kenney UCP (2019–2022):** Bill 20 (Fiscal Measures and Taxation Act) — AISH de-indexed from CPI within fifteen months of the Notley indexation. The federal \$10/day childcare agreement (2021). The structural unwinding of the Notley-era gains begins.
- **Phase Eight — Danielle Smith UCP (2022–present):** Bill 12. The CDB clawback. The AISH inflation cap at 2% below CPI. ADAP. The 88% cohabitation rule. The present moment.
- **Phase Nine — Synthesis:** the comparative trends across all eras (AISH rate vs. CPI over time; caseload over time; appeal rights over time; childcare access over time); the thesis stated in full; the case for community-led representation now.

Each phase is built to the same evidentiary standard as the Lougheed chapter above. Each is sourced to primary government documents, contemporaneous reporting, peer-reviewed analysis, and the Disability Sector Legacy Project timeline. Each ends, where applicable, with the most direct documented words of those who lived through the era and are still alive to speak to it.

The final document, when complete, will be a forty-seven-year evidentiary record of why no Alberta government, of any party, has been a durable enough ally to make partisan-aligned advocacy a viable strategy for the disability community. The conclusion the record establishes is the campaign's reason for being. It is also the reason this work continues.

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